PIA3142 Global Social Movements — Lichbach (1995), The Rebel's Dilemma, Ch. 1: The Problem Defined

1. The Chapter's Problem and Roadmap — Defining the Book's Problematique

Keywords: problematique, DA vs CA, five sections, Lakatos and Popper

- Lichbach 1995, *The Rebel's Dilemma* (University of Michigan Press), Ch. 1, "The Problem Defined" — the required Week 2 reading (book pp. 3–13).
- Opening sentence: "This chapter defines the book's problematique" → problematique — the guiding question of a research program.
- Roadmap: 1.1 an example (p. 3); 1.2 the DA program's answer (p. 4); 1.3 the CA program (p. 5); 1.4–1.5 the two receptions (pp. 7, 11).
- Purpose (p. 4): "to explore the implications of the CA research program for the major puzzles and problems of the causes, courses, and consequences of collective dissent", evaluated "in both Lakatos's (1970) and Popper's (1968) senses."
- The whole chapter hangs on one contrast: DA versus CA.

2. The Puzzle in Miniature — Jane Smith and The Cause (section 1.1)

Keywords: Jane Smith, University of Colorado, affirmative action, picket, running example

2.1 The Thought Experiment — A Monday-Morning Picket (p. 3)

Keywords: diversity, discriminatory tenuring, quotas, The Cause, volunteers

- Jane Smith, a University of Colorado undergraduate, supports employment diversity, believes tenuring practices for minorities and women are discriminatory, and advocates affirmative action with quotas for protected classes.
- The Cause, a campus civil rights organization, shares her beliefs and program; it will picket The Administration next Monday at 9:00 A.M. and has called for volunteers.
- The question: will Jane join the demonstration, or wish the picketers well and stay home? *Example: this running example is revisited by every analytical move in the chapter.*
- It stands for the general question — why do individuals participate in collective dissent? — answered by general premises plus conditions unique to Jane.

2.2 The Two Key Definitions — Collective and Dissent

Keywords: collective, dissent, unconventional means, ill-defined boundary

- collective — individuals participate in some group activity.

- dissent — the individuals' objectives are to change government institutions, policies and/or personnel.
- Dissent's means are unconventional: beyond voting and interest-group activity — typically threatening and/or employing physical coercion and/or other illegal activities.
- The concept's boundaries "have always been ill defined" (Zimmermann 1983, chap. 2; Taylor and Jodice 1983, chap. 2); its core behaviours are the "negative cases" to theories of social order (preface, p. xi).

3. The Traditional Answer — the Deprived Actor (DA) Research Program (section 1.2, p. 4)

Keywords: Gurr 1970, deprivation, discontent, beliefs and attitudes

3.1 Core Claim and Mechanisms — Deprivation to Radicalism

Keywords: frustration, just deserts, equity, relative deprivation, alienation, cynicism, consciousness

- Foremost proponent Ted Gurr (1970): deprivation produces discontent, and discontent in turn produces dissent — dissent is caused by preferences, beliefs, and attitudes towards personal deprivations.
- DA theories list cognitive and emotional processes that turn deprivations into dissent; Jane may join because she experiences one or more of:
- frustration over wants she cannot satisfy; lack of just deserts (felt entitlement vs what she got); lack of equity (inputs far exceed outputs); relative deprivation vis-à-vis advantaged groups;
- alienation from an illegitimate, unresponsive government; political cynicism and lack of trust; class or racial consciousness; radicalism and identification with dissident groups (Zimmermann 1983, chap. 4).
- *Example: relative deprivation needs no absolute misery — a group whose expectations outrun its achievements, or whose position improves then reverses, feels more deprived than one always poor.*

3.2 The Expected Causal Chain and Lichbach's Verdict — "Seems Beyond Dispute"

Keywords: grievances, identification, anger, rhetorical question

- The chain: deprivations → grievances about patterns of authority → identification with similarly deprived actors → anger → behavioural dissent.
- Applied to Jane: severe discrimination → profound grievances → deep sympathy for The Cause → angry enough to join the demonstration.
- Lichbach grants the specific processes might be questioned but says the general DA perspective "seems beyond dispute"; his rhetorical question sets up the challenge — is

it not obvious that deprived people become frustrated, the frustrated angry, and the angry often strike out?

4. The Challenge — the Collective Action (CA) Research Program (section 1.3, p. 5)

Keywords: Olson 1965, Tullock 1971a, motivation disputed, PG-PD

4.1 Olson and Tullock — The Logic of Collective Action and the Paradox of Revolution

Keywords: formalisation, assumptions challenged, research program

- First formalised in Mancur Olson's (1965) The Logic of Collective Action; the most-cited application to protest is Gordon Tullock's (1971a) "The Paradox of Revolution."
- *Example: Tullock's paradox — one rebel's participation can never decide the revolution's outcome, so self-interest says stay home, yet revolutions happen.*
- Both dispute the assumptions DA theories make about rebel motivation, and so dispute that individual deprivation leads to collective dissent; Lichbach calls this the CA research program.

4.2 Jane's Problem in Rational-Choice Terms — Exhibit 1, "Jane's Dilemma" (p. 5)

Keywords: Demonstrate or Stay Home, Everyone Else, 2x2 matrix, four outcomes

- Jane chooses Demonstrate (D) or Stay Home (S), weighing outcomes against what she expects Everyone Else to do; the four possibilities form Exhibit 1, "Jane's Dilemma" (p. 5); (D,S) = Jane Demonstrates while Everyone Else Stays Home.
- (D,D) all Demonstrate: benefits = Diversity, costs = Time Lost. (S,D) Jane alone stays home: benefits = Diversity, costs = 0 — The Cause's loss of strength is imperceptible.
- (S,S) all Stay Home: benefits = 0, costs = 0. (D,S) Jane alone demonstrates: benefits = 0, costs = Time Lost.
- Exam-friendly (memorise): Diversity comes if Everyone Else demonstrates; Jane pays Time Lost only when she Demonstrates.
- *Example: Lichbach's aside — campus police are unkind to Jane's solo picket of the dean's office, much kinder when hundreds of students block it.*

4.3 Normative vs Positive Analysis, and Three Labels — PD, PG, Free Riding

Keywords: mutual cooperation, dominant strategy, public goods, non-excludability, free riding

- Normative analysis: all Demonstrate is better for Jane and Everyone Else than all Stay Home — mutual cooperation is in every member's interest.
- Positive analysis: whatever Jane expects others to do, she prefers to Stay Home. If others Demonstrate, benefits come anyway and protest is costly; if others Stay Home, benefits

are unavailable anyway and protest is still costly — her beliefs about others are irrelevant.

- So all Stay Home, no one Demonstrates, The Administration is safe, and the dean conducts business as usual.
- Prisoner's Dilemma (PD): the normative and positive analyses conflict — mutual cooperation is better for everyone, yet individualistically rational behaviour produces mutual noncooperation. *Example: two suspects interrogated separately both confess, though both would gain by silence; Jane's picket is the many-player version.*
- public goods (PG) problem: costs are private and high (time, money, injury risk), while the benefit of success can be enjoyed by anyone regardless of participation. *Example: like national defence or clean air, Jane enjoys an end to discrimination even if she never pickets.*
- Hence each sympathiser wants to free ride: everyone hopes that someone else will absorb the costs, yet everyone wishes to share in the benefits.

4.4 The Odds Stacked Against Dissent — Naming the Two Dilemmas

Keywords: low probability, independence, opportunity costs, Cooperators' Dilemma, Rebel's Dilemma

- "All of the cards seem stacked against large-scale protests and rebellions": a revolt's success is low-probability, and both success and benefits are almost independent of any individual's participation.
- Costs are certain and private: rebels have many competing causes and demands on their time (e.g., forgone wages), and participation is often costly and dangerous — governments maim or murder their enemies.
- → Balance sheet (memorise): benefits are uncertain, shared, and independent of any individual; costs are certain, private, and sometimes fatal — so rebellion, not quiescence, is what needs explaining.
- *Example: a lobby of a few firms organises and wins protection; a latent group of millions of consumers or taxpayers, each with a negligible stake, does not.*
- Unless the CA problem is overcome, rational people will never rebel — rebellions would require irrationality. Cooperators' Dilemma — the general tragedy of all participants in collective action (Lichbach forthcoming). Rebel's Dilemma — the specific tragedy of dissenters.

5. Why the Puzzle Matters — The Empirical Paradox

Keywords: prediction vs observation, 95 per cent, central question, opposite problematiques

5.1 The Empirical Paradox and the Two Categories of People — The 95 Per Cent Case

Keywords: aggrieved nonrebels, those who rebel, silent majority

- The CA argument predicts rational people will not rebel, yet people quite often rebel, sometimes in very large numbers — the paradox or puzzle of CA.
- Category 1: the aggrieved who do not rebel — by far the larger group: at least ninety-five per cent of aggrieved people, at least ninety-five per cent of the time, in at least ninety-five per cent of places. Critics ignore it, yet it fits Olson.
- Category 2: those who do rebel — the smaller group, but some do overcome the Rebel's Dilemma; this is the puzzle.
- *Example: the 95 per cent figure is an order-of-magnitude claim, not a statistic — it names the silent-majority case that a theory of rebellion must explain rather than explain away.*

5.2 The Central Question and Opposite Problematiques — Gurr vs Olson

Keywords: cooperation, sacrifice, unity, selective incentives

- The book's central question: How is the Rebel's Dilemma solved? Under what circumstances will cooperation emerge? What induces an individual to make a sacrifice to obtain a PG?
- DA theorists, Marxists, Weberians, and agenda setters all seek the same thing from their own perspectives: the causes of political unity — what lets groups form and people defend common interests.
- Opposite problematiques: given ubiquitous grievances, Gurr (1970) must explain why people do not rebel; given ubiquitous free riding, Olson (1965) must explain why people do rebel — via selective incentives and federal group solutions.

6. First Reception — Applied Students of Collective Dissent (section 1.4, p. 7)

Keywords: the marriage, sociologists, political scientists, economists, largely failed

6.1 The Marriage Brokers — General Borrowings, Not the Rebel's Dilemma

Keywords: rational action, bargaining, nonelites, Tarrow

- Students of conflict tried to wed CA ideas to conflict studies; the "marriage brokers" were sociologists, political scientists, and economists who drew on the general rational-actor argument, not the specific dilemma.
- Political violence was redefined in rational-action terms (Zimmermann 1983, 603–4, fn. 47) and as bargaining: "acts of disruption, destruction, injury whose purpose, choice of targets or victims, surrounding circumstances, implementation, and/or effects have political significance..." (Nieburg 1969, 13).
- Nonelites too calculate costs and benefits (Armstrong 1976, 394); Tarrow (1989, 8, 16) — people protest when other routes to their interests are less productive, or gains outweigh costs. Widely cited: Oberschall (1973), Zald and McCarthy (1990), Korpi (1974), Gamson (1990), Tilly (1978), Blalock (1989).

6.2 Tilly (1978) — Collective Rationality as Evasion

Keywords: group benefits vs group costs, Marxist question, Adam Smith and Karl Marx

- Tilly (1978) rejects individual rationality for collective rationality — participation when the group's benefits exceed the group's costs — guided by the Marxist question of group conflict, not the CA question; his model is Adam Smith plus Karl Marx.
- As Gamson (1990, 138) puts it: "The collective goals of political actors rather than the personal goals of members are assumed to be the relevant part of an explanation of political behavior."
- He never explains how the Rebel's Dilemma is solved — an alternative, not a solution; Gamson and Zald & McCarthy proceed likewise, borrowing only selective incentives and entrepreneurs.
- → One-liner: changing the subject from individual to group rationality is evasion, not solution — the Rebel's Dilemma is never answered.

6.3 Economists, the Two Negative Consequences, and the Verdict — "The Marriage ... Has Largely Failed"

Keywords: Olson's Problem, expected utility, Marwell and Oliver, Mueller, theory vs substance

- Economists split into models that do **not** confront Olson's Problem (externalities and PGs Olson 1969; positional goods Shubik 1971; contract-curve tradeoffs Hirshleifer 1987; regime and opposition calculus Lichbach 1984, 1987; Wintrobe 1990; state-opposition games Sandler, Tschirhart, and Cauley 1983; consociational institutions Tsebelis 1990);
- and models that **do** capture his insights (Lichbach 1992, 345–47): binary expected-utility models (Tullock 1971a; DeNardo 1985; Muller and Opp 1986; Opp 1989), continuous models (riots, hijacking, terrorism, revolution — Landes 1978; Sandler and Scott 1987; Mueller 1989, 173–75), and PD models (Buchanan 1979). These take the PG-PD problem seriously: without selective incentives, a rational person will ordinarily not rebel.
- Two negative consequences followed: the bulk of CA ideas was ignored, so its explanatory potential was never exploited; and the bulk of its implications for collective dissent went unexplored.
- Marwell and Oliver (1984, 3): "Although Olson's work has thus had a general impact on social movement theory, *most* of his analysis is only marginally considered in that literature"; (1984, 2): "Everyone assumes that collective action and social movements have a close relationship, but the nature of that relationship remains ill-defined."
- Verdict: "The marriage between the CA research program and conflict studies, in short, has largely failed" — sociologists and political scientists ignored the theory, economists the substance; the contrast with Gurr, who derived integrated propositions about domestic conflict, is stark.

- Economists agree: Mueller (1989, 175) — the rational-behaviour approach "does not generate a rich harvest of testable implications"; Eggertsson (1990, 73–74) — Tullock's theory of revolution shows the limits of the purely economic approach where free riding pays. → One-liner: the theorists never applied their theory; the applied scholars never used it.

6.4 Olson's Own Inconsistent Position — Waffling on Mass Movements

Keywords: amoral familism, utopia, "lunatic fringe", later confidence

- Olson (1965, 161–62) apparently believes "mass movements" are better explained by social psychological and collective behaviour theories than by his own — but he waffles.
- Confident side: mass movements are "usually not very massive" (p. 162); his theory fits the amoral familism culture discovered by Banfield (1958) (p. 162, fn. 97); utopia could be rational because "if the benefit that would come from establishing a utopia is infinite, it could be rational even for the member of a large group to contribute voluntarily..." (p. 161, fn. 94).
- *Example: the utopia case is the one case Olson concedes can defeat his logic — a group so large that no individual contribution matters still mobilises if the payoff is treated as infinite.*
- Most ironically, Olson is confident that an alternative approach — DA-style explanation by "alienation", fanatic devotion to an ideology or leader, and the "lunatic fringe" — works where his own fails; he later regained confidence (Olson 1990, 1991a–d).

7. Second Reception — Pure Theorists of Collective Action (section 1.5, p. 11)

Keywords: the happier story, four assumptions, two dozen solutions, irony

7.1 The Happier Story and the Four Assumptions — Utility Maximizers to No Impact

Keywords: obvious challenge, two categories, PG demands, very large group, individual irrelevance

- While conflict scholars met Olson with disinterest, CA theorists busily elaborated his argument — "the happier story"; the obvious challenge is that Olson is simply wrong (people do rebel, often in large numbers).
- CA analysis rests on four assumptions: (1) individuals are utility maximizers evaluating outcomes of possible actions; (2) demands are typically for a PG; (3) the group of potential sympathisers is very large (thousands); (4) large groups can affect policy, but each individual's participation has no discernible impact on success.

7.2 Solving the Dilemma, and Lichbach's Closing Summary — Revise the Assumptions and Remedy the Field

Keywords: more than two tactics, uncertainty, more than two dozen solutions, next chapter

- The dilemma is solved by revising the assumptions: widening the choice beyond two tactics (staying home, voting, lobbying, demonstrating), allowing more than two expectations about others, and introducing uncertainty about outcomes.
- Most CA theorists accordingly propose free-rider solutions — modifying the basic PG-PD game (Lichbach forthcoming, chap. 2); there are presently more than two dozen distinct solutions to Olson's Problem (Exhibit 2.1, p. 21). *Example: once Jane's choice set widens beyond {D, S}, the 2x2 game no longer describes her decision and a solution becomes possible.*
- Closing summary: the marriage of CA theory with conflict studies failed — few ideas used, few issues studied — which is ironic given the two dozen solutions; the book's purpose is to remedy this and bring the CA program's richness to bear on conflict studies. The next chapter outlines the approach.

8. Where the Book Goes Next — The Four Families of Solutions (from the book's contents)

Keywords: table of contents, provenance, Market, Community, Contract, Hierarchy

- Provenance: from the table of contents bound with Chapter 1 — orientation only, not chapter content; Chapter 1 promises the survey, later parts deliver it.
- Market — increase benefits; lower costs (no-cost, low-cost, opportunity, fixed); increase resources; improve the productivity of tactics (production function, innovations, violence vs nonviolence); reduce the PG's supply; raise the probability of winning and of making a difference; use incomplete information (publicity, illusions, ideology, symbols; control of information); increase risk taking; team competition between enemies; restrict exit; change the type of PG (public bads, nonrival PGs).
- Community — common knowledge (mutual expectations; bandwagon: temporal and spatial diffusion) and common values (process orientation; other-regardingness).
- Contract — types (self-government; tit-for-tat; mutual exchange) and origins (longevity, homogeneity, preexisting organization, autonomy, stability, concentration).
- Hierarchy — entrepreneurs and patrons; reorganise (club, efficacious group, federal structure); team competition among allies; impose, monitor, enforce agreements — selective incentives and disincentives.
- Themes and appraisal: Chapter 7, Solutions as Politics (origins; the Rebel's Dilemma vs the State's Dilemma); Chapter 8, Solutions as Pathologies (unintended consequences; the Iron Laws); Chapter 9 evaluates CA theories (intersolution comparison; predictability — grievances, preference falsification; Lakatos and Popper applied to the four families); Chapter 10 improves them (deepen the micro; explore the macro);

Chapter 11, A Final Perspective. Exhibits: 1.1 Jane's Dilemma (p. 5); 2.1 Solutions (p. 21).

9. Lichbach's Own Position and Project

Keywords: anger is not enough, Tilly's evasion, rich program unused, remedial and evaluative

- What he rejects: that deprivation's anger suffices — the Rebel's Dilemma must be solved for rebellion to occur; Tilly's collective rationality, which never says how; and both halves of the failed marriage — conflict scholars ignored the theory, economists the substance.
- His diagnosis: the CA program is rich (more than two dozen PG-PD solutions) and conflict studies has not used it.
- His project: explore the CA program's implications for the causes, courses, and consequences of collective dissent and evaluate it in Lakatos's (1970) and Popper's (1968) senses; his contribution in this chapter is naming the Cooperators' Dilemma and the Rebel's Dilemma.
- The question the book pursues: How is the Rebel's Dilemma solved? The approach: modify the basic PG-PD assumptions and survey the solutions (Chapter 2, "The Approach Adopted").

10. Working Vocabulary and Key Names

Keywords: definition bank, research programs, dilemma vocabulary, named scholars

10.1 The Research Programs and the Dilemma Vocabulary — DA, CA, PD, PG

Keywords: deprived actor, collective action, problematique, free rider, Olson's Problem

- DA (Deprived Actor) — the traditional approach: deprivation produces discontent, discontent produces dissent (foremost proponent Gurr 1970).
- CA (Collective Action) — the rational-choice approach inaugurated by Olson (1965), disputing that deprivation leads to dissent.
- problematique — the guiding question of a research program. Gurr's: why do people not rebel? Olson's: why do people rebel?
- PD (Prisoner's Dilemma) — individually rational behaviour produces mutual noncooperation even though mutual cooperation is better for everyone.
- PG (public goods) problem — the benefit of a successful protest can be enjoyed by anyone regardless of participation.
- free rider — someone who hopes others will absorb the costs while still sharing the benefits.
- PG-PD game — Lichbach's shorthand for the basic model CA theorists modify.
- Cooperators' Dilemma — the general tragedy of all participants in CA. Rebel's Dilemma — the specific tragedy of dissenters.

- Olson's Problem — how the free-rider problem is overcome; the question Olson leaves unanswered: why people do rebel.
- Olson's General Law of Collective Action — large groups tend to fail to organise for collective goods; deviations from it are what CA theorists explain.
- the paradox or puzzle of CA — people do rebel, sometimes in very large numbers, despite the CA logic.

10.2 Solutions, Models, and Names — Selective Incentives to Lakatos and Popper

Keywords: selective incentives, federal group solutions, amoral familism, expected utility

- selective incentives — the standard Olson solution to the free-rider problem. federal group solutions — Olson's other named solution.
- amoral familism — the culture discovered by Banfield (1958) that Olson (1965, 162, fn. 97) says his theory fits.
- expected utility models — dissent modelled in binary form (dissent vs nondissent) or continuous form (a continuous level of contributions).
- intersolution comparison and predictability — the analytical and empirical criteria for evaluating CA theories (Chapter 9).
- collective dissent — group activity to change government institutions, policies and/or personnel, by means beyond voting and interest-group activity.
- Foundational works: Olson (1965); Tullock (1971a); Gurr (1970); Tilly (1978); Gamson (1990); Marwell and Oliver (1984). Method: Lakatos (1970), Popper (1968); Lichbach's own: Lichbach (1984, 1987, 1990, 1992, forthcoming).

11. One-Page Revision Spine

Keywords: rapid recall, one line per section, exam checklist

1. Lichbach 1995, *The Rebel's Dilemma*, Ch. 1 (pp. 3–13): defines the book's problematique; five sections (pp. 3, 4, 5, 7, 11).
2. Organising contrast: DA (Deprived Actor) versus CA (Collective Action).
3. Gurr (1970): deprivation produces discontent, and discontent produces dissent.
4. DA mechanisms: frustration, just deserts, inequity, relative deprivation, alienation, cynicism, consciousness, radicalism (Zimmermann 1983, chap. 4).
5. Running example: Jane Smith decides whether to join The Cause's Monday picket (p. 3).
6. Definitions: collective — participation in some group activity; dissent — changing government institutions, policies and/or personnel by unconventional means.
7. Olson (1965), The Logic of Collective Action; Tullock (1971a), "The Paradox of Revolution".
8. Jane's 2x2 game, Exhibit 1 (p. 5): Demonstrate (D) or Stay Home (S) against Everyone Else.
9. Outcomes: (D,D) Diversity / Time Lost; (S,D) Diversity / 0; (S,S) 0 / 0; (D,S) 0 / Time Lost.

10. Normative analysis: mutual cooperation is in every member's interest. Positive analysis: she prefers to Stay Home whatever others do.
11. So all stay home, no one demonstrates, and the dean conducts business as usual.
12. Three labels: Prisoner's Dilemma (normative vs positive); public goods problem (benefits cannot be withheld); free riding (let others pay).
13. Odds against dissent: benefits low-probability, shared, independent of the individual; costs certain, private, dangerous (forgone wages).
14. Two named tragedies: Cooperators' Dilemma (general) and Rebel's Dilemma (specific).
15. Empirical puzzle: rational people should not rebel, yet they quite often do — the paradox or puzzle of CA.
16. The 95 per cent claim: most aggrieved people never rebel; a few overcome the dilemma.
17. Central question: How is the Rebel's Dilemma solved? What induces sacrifice for a PG?
18. Opposite problematiques: Gurr (1970) — why people do not rebel; Olson (1965) — why they do (selective incentives, federal groups).
19. Section 1.4 verdict: "The marriage between the CA research program and conflict studies, in short, has largely failed."
20. Tilly (1978)'s collective rationality is an alternative, not a solution — the dilemma is never answered.
21. Section 1.5 — "the happier story": four assumptions revised → more than two dozen solutions.
22. Project: bring the solutions to bear on collective dissent, evaluated in Lakatos's (1970) and Popper's (1968) senses.